

IN HER OWN WORDS . . .

Our family matriarch, Elizabeth, reckons it's the mother's role to recognize these problems—and to solve them. She has to use her rational brain to understand the family's trusts, business, and tax strategies. But she must also use her intuition and instinct to foresee personal issues that could lead to conflict.

Elizabeth's family history prepared her for the matriarch role. In her own words:

In my own family, there was not enough money to permit one brother to buy the other out and no daughter-in-law able to come to the rescue. My grandfather, who married very late in life, was born in 1864, after his father came home from the Civil War. He and his siblings lived in the twentieth century as though it were still the 1800s—on inherited commercial property and textile mills. And we know what happened to mills in the Northeast! They had careers as diplomats and soldiers, but they never worried about earning power.

My grandparents were no fools and saw which way the wind was blowing. They sent both sons to graduate school—my uncle to study business, and my father to train as an engineer at MIT.

My grandparents did what they could. The family was very close, and they educated their sons to be able to support themselves and a family.

Nevertheless, it was a very difficult succession. My father and his brother inherited equally the large house and land in the Hudson River Valley of New York, an estate that had remained in the family since colonial times. One of my ancestors had had the house built for his bride. That property's history was intertwined with the history of my family. But it just was not possible to share, with two wives and two sets of children, and it was painfully difficult to divide. To make matters worse, my father died suddenly during the division, and the breach never had time to heal.

And I know that this is far from an isolated example because I still remember my mother's father telling me about the division of *his* family property with *his* only brother. My grandfather lived to be 100 years old, yet the memory still pained him. (In his case, there was little to divide, since his parents had invested in steamship ferries in Canada and had lost just about everything! But there were books and papers and bibelots—and he came home to find that his brother was burning it all in a bonfire. And, unfortunately, behind the resentment he felt was the sense that his brother was the privileged one, the one who was sent to university while he had to go out to work.)

I never wanted those things to happen in my family.

I have tried to learn from the challenges faced by my forebears and from the failures I have observed. I have thought a lot about the subject. And though I may not be able to give a formula that will *ineluctably* protect your family from failure, I can give you three observations based on my own observations.

Only strong families keep the fortune in the family. We do not want our money to destroy our families. We don't want inheritance battles. We would like to avoid divorces and disgruntled or designing spouses. So we have to build strong families.

Well, how do we do that? I have noticed time and again that strong families are built around strong, shared values. A strong, shared identity. I'm sure most of you have heard